GRADUATE EMPLOYABILITY / PROJECT CONCEPT

Think You Can Build

Show how you solve business problems

Expanded project breakdown: concept, system, operations, assessment, technology, evidence, and pilot plan.

Document status	Concept / pre-pilot
Founder and team	Founder-led; no additional members confirmed
Context	South Africa
Format	3-5 graduates; individual attempts in a shared facilitated call
Prepared	29 October 2026

Evidence boundary

No app, user research, pilot, company partnership, or hiring outcome has been completed. Proposed details and targets are labelled as such; this document is a plan for what to test.

1. Executive overview

Think You Can Build is a proposed live problem-solving show and graduate talent showcase. Three to five graduates attempt the same computer-based business case individually while sharing one facilitated call. The facilitator acts as a senior colleague or project lead: they introduce the case, ask consistent questions, prompt candidates to explain their reasoning, and help make each attempt visible.

The project aims to add practical evidence to early-career hiring. It asks whether employers can learn something decision-relevant by observing a graduate work through a realistic task, explain trade-offs, and respond to new information. The challenge supplements CVs and interviews; it does not replace them or guarantee a job.

Working tagline: Show how you solve business problems.

Initial case and rewards

First-round cases will be fictional mock-company scenarios or carefully adapted hypothetical cases. Later, businesses may submit problems; written permission, case scope, confidentiality, solution-use terms, and any bounty should be agreed before publication. The goal of approaching 20 companies in the launch month is an outreach target, not a list of partners.

For the initial MVP, the founder intends to provide interview and presentation grooming plus CV review/building to challenge winners. Short shadowing or internships, paid roles, company interviews, and cash bounties are possible outcomes only if agreed with the relevant employer. They are not guaranteed. YouTube revenue is speculative and should not fund the MVP plan.

What the first MVP should prove

- Can a small, facilitated challenge be run safely and fairly with existing tools?
- Can independent reviewers score individual work using a common rubric?
- Do graduates find the process and feedback useful?
- Do relevant employers find the evidence useful enough to review or follow up?
- Can the workflow be repeated without an unsustainable workload?

What is out of scope

- A full recruitment marketplace or custom video platform.
- Automated ranking or AI-based candidate scoring.
- A guaranteed job, internship, bounty, or business adoption.
- A claim that the format has already reduced unemployment.

2. Problem and evidence

The hiring evidence gap

Some graduates have relevant academic, project, volunteering, or personal work but limited formal employment history. Employers may have little comparable evidence of how these candidates approach unfamiliar tasks, communicate decisions, or respond to feedback. CV screening and short interviews can leave those capabilities under-observed. The proposed problem is an evidence gap: a candidate may be capable, but the employer cannot confidently observe that capability early in the process.

This is a hypothesis from the challenge framing and founder experience. It needs validation through interviews with graduates and employers. It is not proven by the national unemployment rate.

South African context

Statistics South Africa Q2 2026 reported an official unemployment rate of 33.6%. The graduate rate was 12.4%; the rate for people with other tertiary qualifications was 24.0%. Stats SA reports these categories separately. The figures establish context but do not show why graduates are unemployed or prove that Think You Can Build would improve hiring.

The founder has observed peers from their own 2019/2020 college cohort and the cohort one year below struggling to work in their field. The cohort counts are not yet clear and this is not representative research. Do not quote a numerical cohort rate until the cohort sizes and counts are confirmed.

Problem statement

How might employers see credible evidence of what graduates can do before those graduates have had the chance to build formal experience, while keeping the assessment useful, fair, and safe for participants?

Pilot audience and field selection

The first field is undecided. Select it after surveying graduates and speaking with employers. Compare graduate demand, employer relevance, whether a realistic task can be completed on a computer, accessibility, equipment requirements, and case sensitivity. Existing Stats SA education-level rates do not identify which occupation has the highest graduate unemployment. Avoid claiming that a field is selected on that basis without field-specific evidence.

3. Stakeholders and decision power

Stakeholder	Need / contribution	Decision power or dependency
Graduates	Demonstrate work; receive clear terms and useful feedback.	Choose whether to participate; bear exposure and reputation risks.
Employers / sponsors	See relevant evidence; submit or validate a case; consider follow-up.	Control interviews, hiring, business validation, and funding.
Facilitator	Run a consistent session, ask prompts, maintain balanced participation.	Shapes what reviewers can observe and how candidates are treated.
Second reviewer / mentor	Apply the rubric independently and support candidate development.	Influences shortlist, winner, and feedback quality.
Viewers / recruiters	Observe candidate work and discover talent.	May create exposure; comments may also create pressure or bias.
Founder / production	Source cases, manage workflow, consent, streaming, and moderation.	Controls design and scale; currently operates alone.
Future partners	Potentially source candidates, employers, cases, or coaching.	None is confirmed today.

Incentives and power imbalance

- Employers want useful signals at reasonable cost; shortlisting pressure may encourage reliance on familiar credentials and referrals.
- Graduates want exposure and experience but may accept public visibility because they believe it may lead to opportunities.
- The founder needs a repeatable show format and audience, but engagement should not outrank candidate welfare or assessment quality.
- Reviewers may value different traits unless the criteria and evidence anchors are explicit.
- Viewer engagement can widen reach but may reward entertainment, camera confidence, or popularity rather than work quality.

The project can add an evidence channel. It cannot require employers to use that evidence or create vacancies. Candidate protection therefore matters: participants have less control over how viewers interpret a public recording than employers do.

4. System map and intervention point

Working system loop

Step	Relationship to investigate
1	Entry-level jobs ask for experience or proof of readiness.
2	Graduates without formal roles have fewer professional examples.
3	Short CV screens and interviews offer limited observation of practical work.
4	Hiring teams may rely more on familiar signals, referrals, institutions, or job titles.
5	Candidates who miss a first opportunity have fewer chances to build requested experience.

This is a working system hypothesis, not a proven causal model. Graduate and employer interviews should test each link.

Potential leverage point

Add a short, structured, role-relevant work sample before a decision. The useful change is not simply publishing a video: the task must be comparable, the individual contribution must be visible, the rubric must reward evidence and reasoning, and an employer must be able to interpret the result.

Conditions that must connect

- The task resembles meaningful work in the target role.
- The facilitator asks consistent prompts without completing work or giving unequal hints.
- The rubric rewards problem understanding, reasoning, feasibility, communication, collaboration, and learning from feedback rather than performance polish.
- The employer trusts the case, scoring process, and evidence provenance.
- The challenge is treated as one sample, not a complete judgment of role fit.

Theory of change

1. A bounded task lets a graduate show more than a CV alone.
2. Consistent facilitation and rubric scoring let reviewers compare specific evidence.
3. If relevant employers trust and review that evidence, they may request follow-up conversations or use it in hiring.
4. Feedback and grooming may improve a participant's ability to explain work in later interviews.

Each transition is a hypothesis. Views are not proof of employer use; a single interview is not proof of job impact. The pilot should measure the chain.

5. Challenge format and operating playbook

Challenge lifecycle

1. Select a computer-based field through discovery research.
2. Write a fictional mock-company brief with user need, context, constraints, tools allowed, and success criteria.
3. Have a facilitator and independent reviewer inspect the brief for ambiguity, bias, scope, accessibility, and confidentiality.
4. Publish the challenge, rubric, public-stream conditions, recording and reuse terms, and confirmed rewards before registration.
5. Collect only necessary participant information and complete consent and technical checks.
6. Run the shared call; each graduate makes an individual attempt.
7. Facilitator and second reviewer score evidence independently; compare rationale and decide the shortlist or winner.
8. Provide candidate reflection and promised winner coaching/CV benefit; arrange company follow-up only if agreed.

Draft session length and schedule

A 90-120 minute call is a planning estimate for three to five participants, not a commitment. Complexity and technical setup may change the duration. Dry-run the session before inviting candidates.

Segment	Draft time	Facilitator practice
Welcome / tech / terms	10 min	Confirm public-stream terms, names, support needs, and stop/pause process.
Case briefing	10 min	Read the same prompt, context, constraints, and success measures to all.
Clarifying questions	10 min	Answer consistently; share material new facts with all participants.
Individual attempt / discussion	35-50 min	Invite each candidate to explain assumptions, attempt, and next step.
Solution presentations	5-7 min each	Use the same prompt and time allocation.
Reflection and close	10 min	Ask what changed, what to test next, and gather post-session feedback.

Facilitator playbook

- Use open questions: What are you assuming? What would you test? What changed after new information?
- Balance the discussion so one participant does not dominate.
- Do not provide unequal hints or coach one candidate during scoring.
- Keep timestamped evidence notes for each person.
- Separate post-assessment coaching from assessment itself.
- Pause or stop if a participant asks, private information is exposed, or a safety concern arises.

Individual evidence record

Record the challenge version, participant identifier/name chosen for publication, task artifact or demonstration, timestamped evidence, rubric scores and rationale, candidate reflection, feedback, and consent/version status. Keep contact details and private administrative data separate from public profile material. Define access and retention before collecting data.

6. Assessment rubric and reviewer protocol

Use a 1-5 scale for each criterion, with evidence notes. Equal weighting is a simple starting point for a pilot, not a validated scoring model. A total score may support a shortlist but should not act as an automatic hiring rank. A score describes performance on this task, not the overall worth or potential of a person.

Criterion	1 - Limited evidence	3 - Clear baseline	5 - Strong evidence
Problem understanding	Misses the need or constraints.	Identifies main need and asks useful questions.	Frames underlying need, distinguishes symptoms, revises with new facts.
Reasoning	Conclusion with little explanation or testing.	Explains plausible approach and checks an assumption.	Compares options, tests assumptions, explains why chosen approach fits.
Feasibility	Solution ignores practical constraints.	Proposes workable next step and names a limitation.	Shows implementation path, dependencies, trade-offs, and validation.
Communication	Hard to follow or does not answer question.	Explains approach and responds adequately.	Communicates structure and uncertainty clearly; adapts for audience.
Collaboration	Does not engage constructively.	Listens and contributes respectfully.	Makes room for others, improves shared understanding, disagrees well.
Learning from feedback	Does not consider new information.	Makes a reasonable adjustment after a prompt.	Seeks feedback and explains how it changed the next iteration.

Review sequence

1. Facilitator scores each candidate and cites one observable example per criterion.
2. Second reviewer scores strongest submissions independently where practical.
3. Reviewers compare evidence and record why a shortlist/winner was selected.
4. Candidate self-review informs coaching; it does not replace independent scoring.
5. Viewer comments are moderated and excluded from official scores.
6. Share feedback with participants and allow factual corrections to the record.

Fairness checks

- Same brief, time, and core prompts for all candidates.
- Record individual evidence and opportunity to speak; do not equate airtime with ability.
- Note whether camera confidence, accent, internet, or device quality affected what reviewers saw.
- Offer reasonable accommodations where feasible and protect accommodation details.
- Compare reviewer scores; large differences point to unclear criteria or inconsistent scoring.

7. MVP scope and technical approach

What to build first

The first MVP should prove that one challenge can be run, assessed, and explained safely. Start with a static project page, one challenge brief, a hosted interest form, a shared rubric, and a manual call/stream workflow. Build a larger dashboard only after testing the workflow.

In scope	Out of scope initially
One mock-company case; 3-5 graduates; individual attempts; facilitator; second reviewer; common rubric; replay; candidate feedback; winner grooming and CV review.	AI scoring; full talent marketplace; custom video hosting; automated candidate ranks; guaranteed internships/jobs/bounties; custom OBS remote-control portal.

Proposed MERN architecture

Layer	Role	MVP choice / constraint
React	Landing page, challenge details, interest sign-up, replay links.	Keep public data minimal; implement only the one-pilot path.
Node.js + Express	Backend routes and validation for challenge/interest data.	Keep reviewer records private; validate inputs and limit access.
MongoDB	Store challenge, consent version/status, scoring, and feedback records if needed.	Define retention and access before collecting identifiable data.
Call platform	Facilitated call and screen share.	Teams or Meet are candidates; compare access and recording settings.
Production	Capture call and screenshare.	OBS or StreamYard; manual process first.
Video host	Live stream or replay.	YouTube is proposed; test visibility, comments, retention, and publication controls.

Data flow

1. Publish fictional case and participant terms.
2. Collect minimum registration information; separate it from public profile.
3. Run call and capture only approved screen/window sources.
4. Publish approved recording; avoid exposing private accounts, inboxes, or unrelated desktop content.
5. Store reviewer scores privately; publish only approved summaries.
6. Track follow-up only with participant consent and agreed outcome definitions.

YouTube revenue is uncertain and should not be relied on for launch funding. GPT, Claude, and AI page builders are optional development aids, not core runtime components. Do not send confidential company or personal participant data to AI services without an approved data-handling basis.

8. Feasibility, resources, and validation

Area	Current position	Feasibility condition
Product	Concept only; no working app.	Static landing/prototype and manual workflow first.
Challenge content	Mock cases are possible; role relevance untested.	Graduate/employer discovery and independent review.
Operations	Founder currently solo.	Facilitator, independent reviewer, and moderator for a live pilot.
Employer value	Unknown; no interviews or viewers validated.	Invite relevant reviewers and test what evidence they use.
Funding	No revenue or partnerships confirmed.	Minimal cost pilot; confirm rewards first; no monetization assumption.
Scale	Not demonstrated.	Repeatable runbook, safe moderation, case supply, and demand evidence.

Future operating roles

The founder expects future need for experienced facilitators/mentors, an employer liaison for case and bounty negotiations, and an HR/career-development partner. Production and moderation coverage is also important. These roles are future needs, not secured team members. For a first pilot, some roles may be combined, but independent review and live moderation should not be omitted.

Discovery and field selection

1. Ask graduates what work evidence they can show, where hiring processes fail to reveal skill, whether they would appear publicly, and what access constraints matter.
2. Ask employers how they assess early-career candidates, what evidence they trust, and whether they would review a live challenge, replay, or rubric summary.
3. Compare fields using graduate demand, employer relevance, task feasibility on common devices, access needs, and confidentiality risk.
4. Dry-run the case with volunteers; identify ambiguity, unequal prompts, duration, fatigue, and scoring disagreements.
5. Run a pilot only after the brief, consent, data, moderation, IP, and reward terms are ready.

Research quality

Report who responded, how they were recruited, and how many. Convenience samples are exploratory; do not claim they represent all graduates or employers. Include negative responses and reasons for declining. A survey can inform a choice but cannot prove that the service improves employment.

Sample discovery questions

- Graduates: What work samples do you currently show? What is hard to demonstrate in an interview? Would public recording deter you? What terms and feedback would you need?
- Employers: How do you assess entry-level applicants with limited experience? What work evidence changes your decision? What would make you distrust a streamed assessment? Would you review an actual submission?

9. Measurement and expected impact

Measure the full pathway: access, assessment quality, participant experience, employer use, and later opportunities. Views and comments are engagement, not impact.

Area	Measures	Interpretation
Access	Interest, registration, consent, attendance, completion, withdrawal.	Who can and will take part; possible exclusion.
Assessment quality	Reviewer score gaps, evidence notes, prompt consistency, airtime/opportunity.	Whether rubric is explainable and applied consistently.
Candidate experience	Brief clarity, fairness, pressure, feedback usefulness, confidence explaining work.	Whether process supports learning and what needs revision.
Employer use	Relevant viewers/reviewers; evidence considered useful; follow-up requests.	Whether potential users found decision-relevant information.
Opportunities	Confirmed interviews, shadowing, internships, paid roles, with permission.	Whether exposure is followed by concrete opportunities.
Equity	Participation/outcome patterns where lawful, voluntary, secure, and interpretable.	Potential access or scoring gaps; small samples need caution.

Predefine pilot thresholds

Before the pilot, set numeric targets for participant completion, minimum employer reviewers, reviewer disagreement, feedback turnaround, and rubric clarity. The values are not set yet. Agree them before reviewing pilot results to reduce cherry-picking.

Outcome definitions

- Exposure: a person viewed the stream or replay.
- Employer engagement: an employer reviewed evidence or requested follow-up.
- Interview: confirmed invitation, distinct from grooming practice.
- Internship/shadowing: agreed placement with duration and terms.
- Employment: paid job or contract, confirmed with participant permission.
- Impact: requires repeated evidence and follow-up; one success story does not show causation.

10. Risks, safeguards, and legal review

Risk / trade-off	Why it matters	Proposed safeguard
Public appearance	May exclude people with safety, disability, camera, internet, or privacy constraints.	Disclose before registration; consider an equivalent private/recorded path. If public is mandatory, state the limitation.
Consent and reuse	Participants may feel pressure; public video can be copied or viewed later.	Explain audience, recording, clips, retention, withdrawal limits, and separate reuse permissions.
Presentation bias	Accent, confidence, airtime, and device quality affect perception.	Rubric, consistent prompts, fair turns, accommodations, evidence notes, second review.
Comments / harassment	Comments can harm participants or distort judgments.	Moderate or disable comments; exclude popularity from scoring; report/remove route.
Privacy exposure	Screen share may reveal personal or business details.	Use clean demo environment, approved screen capture, minimum data, access and deletion rules.
Case / IP rights	Adapted real cases can reveal confidential information or imply endorsement.	Use mock cases first; written permission and clear ownership/use/bounty terms for real cases.
Overpromised rewards	Unconfirmed cash, jobs, or internships damage trust.	Advertise only confirmed rewards; negotiate bounties before publication.
Founder capacity	Sourcing, production, scoring, moderation, and follow-up may exceed available founder time.	Limit to one pilot and secure delivery roles before public stream.
Revenue uncertainty	YouTube monetization depends on eligibility, audience, and policy.	Do not rely on channel revenue for MVP costs.

Consent and South African data handling

Consent forms do not alone remove pressure or downstream exposure. Before registration and publication, have the consent language, privacy notice, recording/retention process, and IP terms reviewed against applicable South African requirements by a qualified adviser. This document flags issues for review and is not legal advice.

11. Roadmap, open decisions, and limitations

Phase	Work	Exit evidence
Hackathon prototype	One concept page, one mock-case outline, draft rubric, documented user flow.	Prototype is clearly labeled; judges understand the proposal.
Discovery	Graduate/employer interviews or survey; compare fields.	Findings report with sample and limits; pilot field chosen.
Dry run	Volunteer test of brief, duration, facilitator prompts, scoring, stream setup.	Revised case, runbook, rubric anchors, and tested timing.
Pilot readiness	Confirm facilitator, reviewer, moderator, terms, permissions, promised rewards.	Go/no-go checklist completed.
Pilot	Run one challenge; collect participant/reviewer/employer feedback.	Report results, limitations, risks, and repeat/change/stop recommendation.
Iteration	Refine content/platform; approach companies and negotiate real cases.	Evidence of repeatable demand and operational capacity.

Open decisions

Decision	Current status	Resolution
Pilot field	Undecided.	Discovery and feasibility comparison.
Session length	Undecided; 90-120 minutes is only a draft.	Dry-run task and check fatigue/quality.
Public / private path	Public stream is central to concept.	Decide whether alternate participation preserves exposure while widening access.
Winner selection	Facilitator + second review + self-reflection planned.	Finalize tie-breaks and rationale before recruitment.
20-company goal	Outreach target for launch month.	Track approaches, replies, meetings, commitments separately.
Technology	MERN and video tools proposed, untested.	Test manual workflow before custom features.
Rewards	Coaching/CV review intended; others conditional.	Confirm delivery and terms before announcing.

Limitations

- No app, prototype, research, pilot, employer partnership, or outcome has been completed.
- Unemployment statistics do not establish the cause of an individual graduate's unemployment.
- One challenge shows one performance under specific conditions; it cannot establish general job suitability.
- Public participation selects for people willing and able to be visible; results may not represent all graduates.
- Employers can observe without hiring; hiring and vacancies are outside project control.
- The founder currently works alone; scale, moderation coverage, and repeatability are not demonstrated.

Decision rule after pilot

Continue only if participants understand the terms, reviewers can score with observable evidence, employers find at least some evidence decision-relevant, and the public-exposure and operating risks are manageable. If not, revise the format before adding streams or promising outcomes.

Appendix A. Draft interview and review tools

Graduate discovery prompts

1. What field or role are you trying to enter, and what evidence do you currently show?
2. What is hard to demonstrate in a CV or interview?
3. Would you take part in a public facilitated challenge? What would make you decline?
4. What do you need to know about recording, viewers, comments, and future reuse?
5. What equipment, connectivity, accessibility, or safety conditions affect participation?
6. What feedback or reward would be useful even if no job follows?

Employer discovery prompts

1. How do you assess early-career applicants with limited formal experience?
2. Which practical skills are difficult to see in a CV or short interview?
3. What would make a challenge submission credible and relevant?
4. Would you watch live, review a replay, or read a rubric summary? What would you actually use?
5. What would make you distrust the format or scoring?
6. Could you validate a mock/real case or review a submission? What permission is needed?

Reviewer score sheet

Candidate	Observed evidence / timestamp	Score 1-5	Rationale
Problem understanding			
Reasoning			
Feasibility			
Communication			
Collaboration			
Learning from feedback			

Reviewer declaration: I scored the work shown in this challenge using the published criteria. I separated observable task evidence from assumptions about the candidate, disclosed relevant conflicts, and did not use viewer popularity as a scoring factor.

References

Statistics South Africa. Quarterly Labour Force Survey, Quarter 2: 2026 (P0211). Education-level unemployment rates: graduates 12.4%, other tertiary qualifications 24.0%, official rate 33.6%.

Q2 2026 QLFS PDF

Statistics South Africa. Presentation: Quarterly Labour Force Survey, Q2 2026. Education-level unemployment comparison.

Q2 2026 QLFS presentation

Prepared from founder-provided concept notes and official Stats SA data. Prepared 29 October 2026.